International organizations promote justice

Reporter: Oginie, Kelly, Flora

Reporting date: August 15, 2025

Definition

International Organizations

- Entities composed of member states or private actors operating across national borders to address global issues.
- Examples:United Nations (UN - Peace, Development, Human Rights), World Trade Organization (WTO - Trade Rules), Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs - Advocacy, Service Delivery).

“Justice” in Globalization

- The pursuit of fairness, equity, and the protection of rights within an interconnectd world.
- Key Dimensions: Human Rights (dignity, equality), Economic Fairness (trade equity, development opportunity), Climate Justice (burden-sharing, intergenerational equity).

Core argument:
International Organizations promote justice

- **Rule-Making** :Creating binding treaties and soft law standards that define norms of fairness and set minimum expectations for state behavior.
- **Resource Allocation** : Mobilizing and distributing financial aid, technical expertise, and capacity-building support (e.g., UN Development Programme, World Bank loans/grants) to reduce inequalities and empower disadvantaged states/groups.
- **Monitoring & Accountability**: Implementing oversight mechanisms (e.g., UN treaty bodies, WTO dispute settlement, NGO reporting) to track compliance, expose violations, and pressure states/groups towards fairer practices.

Logic structure: Pathways to fair outcomes

RULES :

International Organizations establish norms, standards, and agreements defining fairness (e.g., Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Paris Agreement, SDGs).

ACTION :

- Operative Mechanisms: Aid programs (UNDP), technical assistance (WHO), dispute resolution (WTO/ICJ).
- Monitoring Mechanisms: Reporting systems, expert reviews, fact-finding missions, NGO shadow reports.
- Advocacy Platforms: Raising awareness, mobilizing public pressure, providing voice for marginalized groups.

RESULT :

- Enhanced Protection: Reduced human rights abuses, stronger legal frameworks.
- Reduced Inequality: Narrowed development gaps, fairer trade benefits, climate adaptation support.

How do IOs promote justice?

1.Establishing a global normative and legal framework:

- By establishing norms such as the UN Charter, the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, etc., international organizations have set "justice" standards regarding sovereignty, human rights, peaceful resolution of disputes, prohibition of aggression, and combating crimes against humanity globally. They provide a legal basis for weak countries to challenge the actions of powerful nations based on international law.

2. Providing platforms for vulnerable countries and groups:

- At institutions such as the United Nations General Assembly, regardless of the size or strength of a country, all have equal voting rights in principle. This provides small and weak countries with valuable opportunities to express their demands on the international stage.

3. Promoting peaceful dispute resolution:

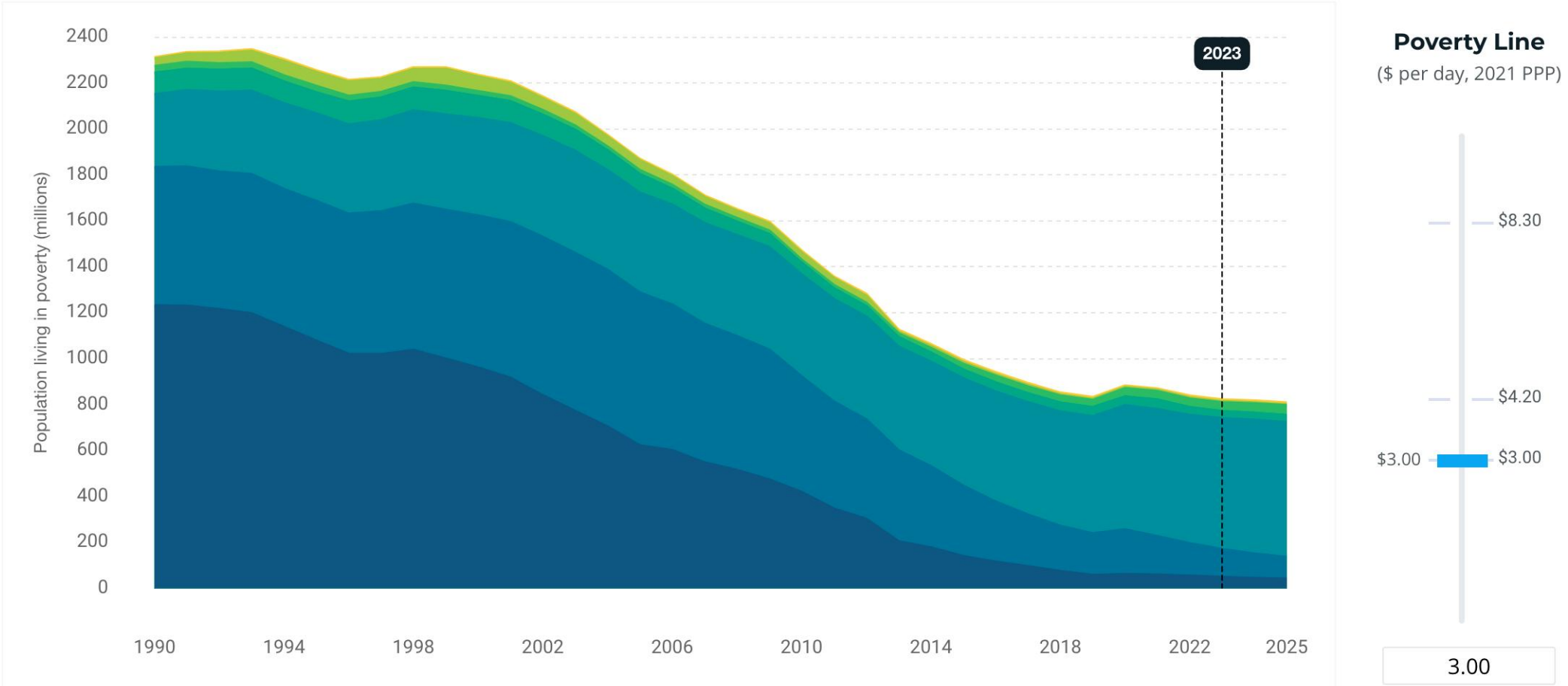
- **Mediation and Peacekeeping:** The UN Security Council plays a central role in mediating international disputes, facilitating ceasefires, and deploying peacekeeping forces. Peacekeeping operations aim to protect civilians, prevent the recurrence of conflicts, and create a stable environment.
- **Post-conflict reconstruction:** International organizations deeply engage in the reconstruction of post-conflict countries, the establishment of the rule of law, the establishment of human rights institutions, and the pursuit of accountability for war criminals.

4. Promoting the Global Development Agenda and Reducing Inequality:

- **Setting Common Goals:** The "Millennium Development Goals" and "Sustainable Development Goals" led by the United Nations have provided a clear direction for global development, emphasizing the reduction of inequality, and addressing global challenges such as climate change.
- **Resource Mobilization and Coordination:** Institutions such as the World Bank, IMF, and the United Nations Development Programme provide development financing, technical assistance, and capacity building to developing countries. Despite certain limitations, their fundamental goal is to promote economic and social development.

people lived below the **$3.00** per day poverty line in 2025

2021 ▼ PPP



Criticism

1.International organizations are controlled by major powers

Although international organizations advocate "multilateral equality", in reality, great powers exert great influence on their decision-making by virtue of their economic, political and military power, resulting in some issues being deadlocked or favoring the interests of great powers.

Case:Since the Syrian civil war in 2011, the Security Council has repeatedly vetoed resolutions due to major power conflicts. As of 2022, Russia and China have jointly vetoed at least 16 drafts. The conflict has been dragging on for a long time, and international organizations seem powerless.

Rebuttal

1.The veto power has led to the obstruction of some resolutions, which reflects the "favoritism" of the international political structure rather than that of the international organization itself. Within the framework of the United Nations, every member state has a say, and small countries can also promote humanitarian issues in the General Assembly and specialized agencies, creating a fair platform for discussion.

2.Chemical weapons destruction: In 2013, under the supervision of the United Nations and OPCW, Syria joined the Chemical Weapons Convention, destroying the majority of its chemical weapons to ensure the safety of civilians.
Humanitarian aid: UNHCR and WFP have provided food, medical and refuge assistance to millions of Syrian civilians, regardless of camp, safeguarding the survival rights of the vulnerable.

Criticism

2.Aid intensifies dependence

Aid from international organizations does not always promote fairness; instead, it may create unfairness in the long run, causing weak countries to become dependent on the outside world.

Case:Somalia's reliance on imported grain exceeds 50%, and local agricultural products lack competitiveness. About 63% of the population in South Sudan relies on external food aid. In some regions, "local grain overstock and free distribution of aid grain" have emerged, weakening agricultural production, hindering economic independence, and exacerbating global inequality between the North and the south.



Rebuttal

1.While providing food aid, international organizations often carry out agricultural training and other activities. For instance, the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) has launched agricultural training programs in South Sudan and Somalia to help farmers master modern planting techniques and food storage methods, thereby enhancing their self-sufficiency.

2.Aid not only provides emergency assistance but also helps vulnerable groups achieve fair development through investment in education, technology and infrastructure. For instance, the FAO and WFP have supported community food reserves and small-scale agricultural projects in South Sudan, gradually reducing reliance on imported food.

Summary

International organizations are subject to political games and efficiency issues, and sometimes decisions are made slowly or are influenced by major powers. However, these limitations do not mean that international organizations cannot play their roles; rather, they need to be constantly improved and perfected.

In the face of transnational issues such as the pandemic, climate change and the refugee crisis, it is difficult to solve them solely through national actions.

International organizations provide multilateral coordination platforms, integrate resources, promote cooperation, and offer fair participation opportunities to all countries.

International organizations are not perfect, but they are the most feasible path to global equity. Promote reform rather than negation, and enable international organizations to more effectively safeguard fairness and justice.

Thank you for listening!